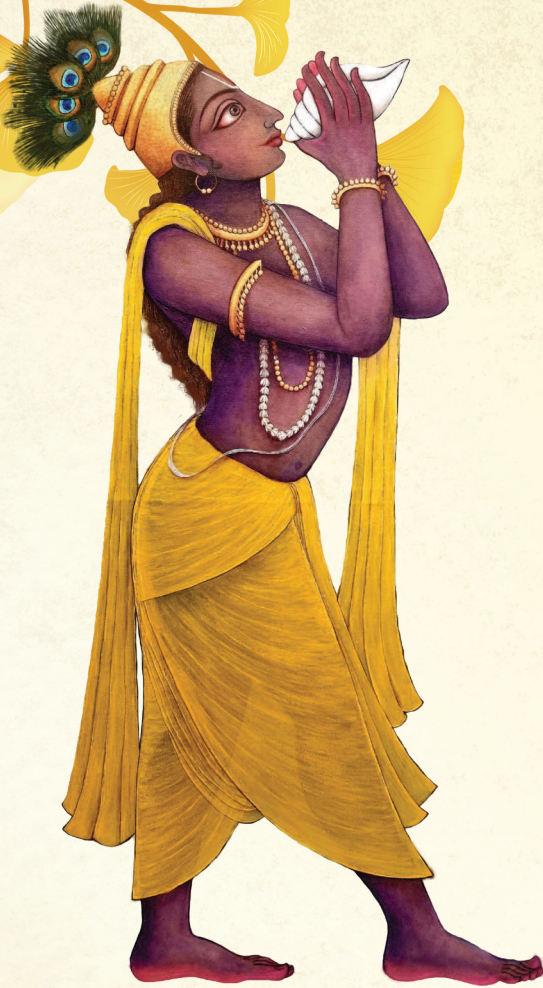




KRISHNA-NITI

TIMELESS STRATEGIC WISDOM

←—————→
Kushagra Aniket • Nityananda Misra

KRISHNA-NITI

Krishna-Niti

Timeless Strategic Wisdom

Kushagra Aniket
Nityananda Misra

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To Ma and Pitaji

—Kushagra

To Rohit and Neha

—Nityananda

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Foreword

BHAGAVAN Sri Krishna is the most complex character in our literature. He is also a historical figure of immense importance. In him we see the ideal combination of *pravrtti* and *nivrtti*, activity and detachment. He is the foremost of *acharyas* for he practised what he preached and established the ideals he espoused in tradition. People rarely live up to their ideals, nor do they elucidate their thoughts for the benefit of posterity. Sri Krishna differs on both these counts: his life is the best exposition of his teachings enshrined in the Bhagavad-Gita. He is also the best representative of Sanatana Dharma. Like our dharma, Krishna too appears to have an apparent contradiction—difficult to understand completely and yet easy to experience!

Sri Krishna was born on the night of *Shravana-Ashtami*, the eighth day in the waning period of the moon in the rainy season. According to our calendar, he was born in *Dakshinayana*—the part of the year that represents the night of the deities. Further, his birth was in the *Krishna-paksha*, the time of the month that represents the night of the *pitrs*, departed souls/manes. In this manner, Sri Krishna was born when the guiding forces of the world comprising the deities, manes and sages were in deep sleep. The natural sources of light—sun, moon, lightning, and fire—were conspicuous by

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their absence on the dark, rainy night of Sri Krishna's birth. In such a time of all-pervasive darkness, the dark child Krishna was born to dispel the darkness of humankind!

This paradox reveals the nature of Sri Krishna: he was not a king but went on to become a kingmaker; he was not high-born but was revered by holy saints; he was not a celibate per se, but he practised the highest level of detachment; he was a great warrior but did not fight in the Kurukshetra battle as a soldier; he was not a Vedic seer but produced a work that stands on par with the Vedas. In the words of Kulapati K.M. Munshi, he was "wise and valorous, loving and loved, far-seeing and yet acting in the living present, gifted with sage-like detachment and yet intensely human; a diplomat, a sage and a man of action with a personality as luminous as that of a divinity".*

Unfortunately, Krishna's well-rounded personality has not been understood well. What's more, it is often misunderstood. Devotees and adherents of various traditional faiths oftentimes truncate Sri Krishna's personality, although they mean no disrespect to the deity they revere. They take him to be a magician, a romantic, a manipulator, a preacher, and a cause of ceaseless wonder. On the other hand, the detractors of Sanatana Dharma wilfully twist Sri Krishna's personality: they ridicule him as a war-monger and put down the Bhagavad-Gita as a manual of violence and hatred.

* * *

**Krishnavatara* (Vol. 5). Bombay: Bharatiya Vidya Bhavan, 1988. p. vii (Introduction).

From the original sources we learn that Sri Krishna was the last person to advocate war.

After the Pandavas complete their stay in the forest along with a year of staying incognito, they hold a meeting to take further action. In his opening address in this meeting—which he had himself convened—Sri Krishna shares his thoughts in the following manner:

एवङ्गते धर्मसुतस्य राज्ञो दुर्योधनस्यापि च यद्धितं स्यात्।
तच्चिन्तयध्वं कुरुपाण्डवानां धर्म्यं च युक्तं च यशस्करं च ॥
अधर्मयुक्तं न च कामयेत राज्यं सुराणामपि धर्मराजः।
धर्मार्थयुक्तं च महीपतित्वं ग्रामेऽपि कस्मिंश्चिदयं बुभूषेत् ॥

evaṅgate dharmasutasya rājño
duryodhanasyāpi ca yaddhitam syāt
taccintayadhvam kurupāṇḍavānām
dharmaṃ ca yuktaṃ ca yaśaskaram ca
adharmayuktaṃ na ca kāmayeta
rājyaṃ surāṇāmapi dharmarājaḥ
dharmārthayuktaṃ ca mahīpatitvam
grāme'pi kasmimścidayaṃ bubhūṣet

(Mahabharata, 5.1.13–14)

“Contemplate on what is good for the king Yudhisthira and Duryodhana. Think about a sustainable and well-suited path for both the Kauravas and Pandavas, which brings them fame. Dharmaraja would not desire even the kingdom of the deities if it is defiled by adharma; he would rather reign in a small village that adheres to dharma.”

When Sri Krishna goes to Hastinavati to broker peace, he stays with Vidura. In a personal conversation with his host,

Sri Krishna reveals his heart:

सोऽहं यतिष्ये प्रशमं क्षत्तः कर्तुममायया ।

so'ham yatiṣye praśamaṁ kṣattaḥ kartumamāyayā

(5.91.8)

न मां ब्रूयुरधर्मज्ञा मूढा असुहृदस्तथा ।

शक्तो नावारयत्कृष्णः संरब्धान् कुरुपाण्डवान् ॥

उभयोः साधयन्नर्थमहमागत इत्युत ।

तत्र यत्नमहं कृत्वा गच्छेयं नृष्ववाच्यताम् ॥

मम धर्मार्थयुक्तं हि श्रुत्वा वाक्यमनामयम् ।

न चेदादास्यते बालो दिष्टस्य वशमेष्यति ॥

अहापयन्पाण्डवार्थं यथावच्छमं कुरूणां यदि चाचरेयम् ।

पुण्यं च मे स्याच्चरितं महार्थं मुच्येरंश्च कुरवो मृत्युपाशात् ॥

na mām brūyuradharmajñā mūḍhā asuhr̥dastathā

śakto nāvārayatkṛṣṇaḥ saṁrabdhān kurupāṇḍavān

ubhayoḥ sādhayannarthamahamāgata ityuta

tatra yatnamahaṁ kṛtvā gaccheyaṁ nṛṣvavācya-tām

mama dharmārthayuktaṁ hi śrutvā vākyamanāmayam

na cedādāsyate bālo diṣṭasya vaśameṣyati

ahāpayanpāṇḍavārthaṁ yathāvac-

chamaṁ kurūṇāṁ yadi cācareyam

puṇyaṁ ca me syāccaritaṁ mahārthaṁ

mucyeraṁśca kuravo mṛtyupāśāt

(5.91.16–19)

“O Vidura, I shall try my best to establish peace without resorting to conceit. ‘When the Kauravas and Pandavas resolved to fight, Krishna was capable of stopping them; but he did nothing!’ Let no ignoble, ignorant, and insensitive person cast such aspersions on me! I shall try to broker peace without

harbouring bias for either party; by this I shall be free from slander. If the ignorant Duryodhana does not part with the kingdom even after hearing my words rooted in dharma, misfortune will befall him. And if I succeed in my mission of establishing peace with the Kurus—without sacrificing the interest of the Pandavas—I will indeed beget *punya*; my conduct will be ennobled; by this the Kurus will be freed from death's noose!”

Sri Krishna further clarifies his position:

न चापि मम पर्याप्ताः सहिताः सर्वपार्थिवाः ।

क्रुद्धस्य प्रमुखे स्थातुं सिंहस्येवतरे मृगाः ॥

na cāpi mama paryāptāḥ sahītāḥ sarvapārthivāḥ
kruddhasya pramukhe sthātum siṃhasyevetare mṛgāḥ

(5.91.21)

“All these kings [who side with Duryodhana in the war] put together cannot ever match up to me! Appearing before me when I am furious, they are like timid deer before the lion.”

This is not an empty boast. At several instances, the epic Mahabharata records Sri Krishna's matchless valour and incisive war strategy.

Despite being supremely capable of crushing his adversaries, Sri Krishna adopts a calm tone of concern when he beseeches the king Duryodhana in the open court:

त्राहि राजन्निमं लोकं न नश्येयुरिमाः प्रजाः ।

त्वयि प्रकृतिमापन्ने शेषं स्यात्कुरुनन्दन ॥

trāhi rājannimam lokam na naśyeyurimāḥ prajāḥ
tvayi prakṛtimāpanne śeṣam syātkurunandana

(5.93.33)

“O King, protect the world—may your subjects not perish. If you undergo a change of heart [and prefer peace], all else will be sorted.”

The Pandavas took to war only after all these prolonged efforts at establishing peace failed. In this manner, it is abundantly clear that Duryodhana is solely responsible for the Kurukshetra war. He has to be held responsible for all its consequences.

When war is inevitable, one should fight to win. Further, in this case, dharma is on the side of the Pandavas for Duryodhana is rooted in adharma. In this manner, the war assumes the dimension of punishing the wicked, and the *yuddha-samhita* (equations of war) changes to *danda-samhita* (equations of punishment). Punishment should be commensurate to the level of dharma-transgression. It is in this background that Sri Krishna utters the following words:

मायावी मायया वध्यः सत्यमेतद्युधिष्ठिर ।

māyāvi māyayā vadhyah satyametadyudhiṣṭhira

(9.30.6)

मायाविनं च राजानं माययैव निकृन्ततु ।

māyāvinam ca rājānam māyayaiva nikṛntatu

(9.57.7)

“O Yudhishtira, a scheming and wily person should be killed by resorting to scheming ways. And so, may [Bhima] pay back the evil king Duryodhana in his own coin.”

By the foregoing, it is clear that Sri Krishna’s *raja-niti* is flawless and comprehensive. The laity often connects with the Mahabharata through local stories, theatrical presentations,

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movies, tele-serials, various adaptations, comments on social media, and so on, which stray away from the vision of the epic. And so it is no wonder that Krishna, the statesman nonpareil, remains elusive.

* * *

The present book *Krishna-Niti: Timeless Strategic Wisdom* authored by Kushagra Aniket and Nityananda Misra serves the need of the hour. The authors base their observations on the original epic and present the true nature of Krishna as a statesman. Kushagra and Nityananda can read and understand the Mahabharata in the original; they have a good grasp of its cultural and philosophical nuances. These merits of the authors make their work authentic and reliable. In our times of chaos and confusion, works like this appear as a whiff of fresh air.

The authors enumerate and analyse Sri Krishna's *raja-niti* as evidenced on numerous occasions: beginning with his initial association with the Pandavas—after Draupadi's wedding—till the completion of the *Ashvamedha*, followed by the *Anu-Gita*. This work is at once concise and comprehensive and serves a long-felt need. I recommend *Krishna-Niti: Timeless Strategic Wisdom* to all readers who seek to understand Sri Krishna's multifaceted personality. I congratulate the authors on a job well done and wish them well in all their future endeavours.

Shatavadhani R. Ganesh

24 November 2023

Bengaluru

Preface

यतो धर्मस्ततः कृष्णो यतः कृष्णस्ततो जयः ।

“Where there is dharma, there is Krishna. Where there is Krishna, there is victory.”¹

यतः कृष्णस्ततो धर्मो यतो धर्मस्ततो जयः ।

“Where there is Krishna, there is dharma. Where there is dharma, there is victory.”²



WITH slight variations, these two oft-quoted statements are repeated throughout the Mahabharata. For instance, in the Udyoga-Parvan, as emissaries are exchanged between the Pandavas and the Kauravas, Vidura counsels the aged king Dhritarashtra to seek peace with the Pandavas, adding, “Where there is truth, dharma, humility, and uprightness, there resides Govinda. Where there is Krishna, there is victory.”³

Later, in the Bhishma-Parvan, before the first day of the great war, Arjuna prays to Devi Durga. Durga blesses him by saying that he would be victorious in the upcoming war. After narrating this account to Dhritarashtra, Sanjaya warns him of the inevitable victory of the Pandavas, “Where there is righteous conduct, dignity, brilliance, humility, prosperity, and intelligence and dharma, there is Krishna. Where there is

Krishna, there is victory.”⁴

In the same Parvan, on the first day of the war, Yudhishtira goes to the enemy camp to seek the blessings of Kaurava elders before the war starts. Drona blesses him by saying that his victory is sure, for Krishna is his minister. Drona then adds, “Where there is dharma, there is Krishna. Where there is Krishna, there is victory. O son of Kunti! Go ahead and fight.”⁵

After facing reverses on the battlefield, when Duryodhana asks Bhishma the reason why the Kaurava warriors cannot stand the might of the Pandavas, Bhishma reveals that Krishna is none other than Narayana and adds, “O King! Krishna is present in everything. He is without any ignorance and attachment. Where there is Krishna, there is dharma, and where there is dharma, there is victory.”⁶

Finally, in the Shalya-Parvan, after Duryodhana is defeated by Bhima, the Pandavas arrive at the Kaurava camp. Krishna congratulates Yudhishtira for the victory in the war. Yudhishtira responds by saying that he remembers what Vyasa had told him in Upaplavya, “Where there is dharma, there is Krishna, and where there is Krishna, there is victory.”⁷

At the end of the Anushasana-Parvan, when Bhishma is about to die after lying on the bed of arrows for many days, he requests Krishna to save him and asks for his permission to leave his body. He then remembers that he had taught Duryodhana, “At that time, I had told that wicked and foolish Duryodhana: Where there is Krishna, there is dharma, and where there is dharma, there is victory.”⁸

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The two equivalent statements, made repeatedly in the epic, emphasise that Krishna is always with dharma and vice-versa, and victory is always with Krishna and dharma. While dharma and Krishna were the reasons that the Pandavas emerged victorious in the battle of Kurukshetra, how was this victory achieved? The answer lies in Krishna's strategic wisdom.

A lot has been and continues to be written about the Bhagavad-Gita, Krishna's spiritual wisdom that was imparted to Arjuna on the battlefield of Kurukshetra just before the great war. So much so that whenever one brings up the topic of Krishna's teachings in the Mahabharata, the first thing, and often the only thing, that comes to mind is the Bhagavad-Gita. However, there is much more to the Krishna of the Mahabharata than the Guru who imparts the divine knowledge of the Bhagavad-Gita to Arjuna. The Mahabharata presents Krishna as the strategist par excellence. He is as worldly wise as he is spiritually enlightened. Some of the instances that reflect his practical wisdom are strategising with the Pandavas in preparation for the Kurukshetra war, serving as the emissary of peace to the Kaurava court, motivating the Pandavas at critical junctures in the war and diffusing several instances of internal conflicts in the Pandava camp. Indeed, while planning to attack Jarasandha, Bhima summarises the three driving forces of the epic: "There is strategy in Krishna, strength in me (Bhima), and victory in Arjuna."⁹

While we are advised to follow the teachings of Krishna, we are often unaware of the actual decision points where Krishna's interventions changed the direction of the epic and

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set an example for the readers of the Mahabharata. For reasons unknown to us, not many notable books have been written about Krishna's practical instructions on worldly wisdom in the Mahabharata. Other instructions in niti have been amply covered. Bhishma's instruction to Yudhishtira in the Shanti-Parvan and the Anushasana-Parvan has been described by J.A.B. van Buitenen as the "longest deathbed sermon on record". It has received considerable attention. The Vidura-Niti (in the Udyoga-Parvan) is well known and many translations of it have been published. The Narada-Niti (in the Sabha-Parvan) are also mentioned often when it comes to statecraft and practical wisdom. Narratives teaching niti in fables with non-human characters in the Mahabharata have been also covered in several books, including the recent *Vyasa-Katha: Fables from the Mahabharata* by one of the authors. Even the Dhritarashtra-Niti (in the Ashramavasika-Parvan) has received the occasional attention. Interestingly, the Mahabharata also contains an example of Kuniti or bad niti, propounded by Kanika, who advised Dhritarashtra to kill the Pandavas after they had demonstrated their abilities at the rangabhumi (convocation arena).¹⁰ However, Krishna's instructions on strategy, morality, and polity in the Mahabharata have not received the attention they rightly deserve.

This book is a first-of-its-kind compilation of the niti instructions of Krishna in the Mahabharata. We have attempted to compile every statement of Krishna on the topics of conduct, practical life, morality, policy, governance, and law from multiple editions of the Mahabharata. As a result, we have

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assembled a set of around 300 verses, which can be presented as an independent work 'Krishna-Niti' in the hoary Indian tradition of niti, which dates back right to the Vedas and boasts of many illustrious teachers, such as Shukra, Brihaspati, Manu, Yajnavalkya, Vidura, Chanakya, Vishnu Sharma, and Kamandaka.

In making his interventions, Krishna often directly or indirectly quotes from several authorities on dharma including Manu, Shukra, Vidura, and Yajnavalkya, who were likely well regarded in his era. We have endeavoured to trace these references, along with pointing out comparisons with later works such as the Panchatantra, Hitopadesha, Chanakya-Niti and Kamandaka-Niti.

While there are several points of similarity between the present work on Krishna-Niti and past works on niti by Shukra, Vidura, and Chanakya, there are also some important differences. Unlike other works on niti, Krishna's instructions are context-specific. They are not theoretical but have an immediate relation to the situation at hand. Krishna's role is not just being a knower of dharma (*dharmajna*) but also being its upholder and institutor (*dharmasamsthapaka*). As a result, his guidance is always delivered to a particular character in the epic, especially in moments of crisis, internal dissension or war. This implies that we also get an opportunity to witness the principles of the Krishna-Niti in action.

A few Mahabharata scholars have argued that Krishna is a mere witness in the Mahabharata. As a pure representation of time, he rarely steps in to change the course of events.

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However, the present work presents sufficient evidence to the contrary. Chapter 1 (Restraining the Enemy) illustrates how Krishna was the mastermind behind the slaying of Jarasandha, which paved the way for Yudhishtira's Rajasuya Yajna. It was at this Rajasuya Yajna that Krishna killed the errant Shishupala. Chapter 2 (Post-Mortem of a Crisis) sees Krishna supporting the just cause of the Pandavas. He vows to anoint Yudhishtira as the king of Hastinapura after defeating the Kauravas. In Chapter 3 (A Just War), Krishna marshals a powerful defence of the Pandavas' cause, explaining to Sanjaya that they were justified in waging war to regain their rightful inheritance. Chapter 4 (Preparing for Battle) offers a glimpse of Krishna as an active participant in the preparations for the Kurukshetra war, testing the resolve of the Pandavas and boosting their morale. Chapter 5 (Fighting for Peace) presents Krishna in the celebrated role of the messenger of the Pandavas. He not only attempts to negotiate with Duryodhana but also sows dissension in his camp and gauges his readiness for the imminent battle. Returning from Hastinapura, Krishna also invites Karna to switch over to the Pandava side but Karna turns down this proposal. Chapter 6 (Dharma in Combat) takes us to Krishna on the battlefield, where he does not take up arms but inspires a dejected Arjuna to fight (which is one of the main teachings of the Bhagavad Gita). He subsequently motivates Arjuna to fell Bhishma and orchestrates the fall of Drona through his arguments to Yudhishtira. In chapter 7 (The Mediator's Dharma), Krishna averts a great calamity for the Pandava army by assisting in resolving a dispute that

erupted between Arjuna and Yudhishthira. In chapter 8 (A Decisive Victory), Krishna ensures the defeat of Duryodhana by Bhima who was bound by his vow to avenge the insult to Draupadi. Chapter 9 (Consoling the Opponent) marks the end of the war when Krishna travels to the Kaurava camp to console the grief-stricken Dhritarashtra and Gandhari. Not only does Krishna provide solace to the aged couple, he also convinces Gandhari to not curse Yudhishthira. Instead, Gandhari curses Krishna, who accepts her curse with grace. In chapter 10 (Inspiring the Victor), Krishna motivates a remorseful Yudhishthira to accept his royal duties and start his reign with an Ashvamedha Yajna. Finally, chapter 11 (The Ruler's Dharma) contains Krishna's final instructions on Vaishnava Dharma to Yudhishthira as he commences his rule. The above instances and several others—including protecting Draupadi in the Kaurava assembly, shielding the Pandavas from Rishi Durvasas' curse, reviving the dead Parikshit, etc.—lead us to conclude that Krishna emerges as a direct intervener in some of the most critical episodes of the Mahabharata. When Krishna desires that the Pandavas “may grow like an ignited flame”, we can be certain that his *niti* is responsible for kindling and magnifying the Tejas of the Pandavas.¹¹

The three primary recipients of Krishna's advice in the Mahabharata are Arjuna, Yudhishthira, and Duryodhana. Krishna's message of dharma is the same to all three. However, they choose to act differently according to their disposition. Following Krishna's advice, Arjuna successfully wins the

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Kurukshetra war but more importantly, emerges as a Karma-Yogin. Similarly, Yudhishtira finds inspiration in the words of Krishna and becomes renowned as a righteous ruler. However, Duryodhana decides to disregard Krishna's message and suffers the consequences of his action.

Each of the eleven chapters in this book corresponds to a different episode in the Mahabharata from which the utterances by Krishna are compiled. We situate each chapter by presenting the context and then present Krishna's wisdom in the original Sanskrit, followed by a simple English translation. At the end of each chapter, we come back to the context of the Mahabharata and present a short summary of the learnings from the Krishna-Niti.

We have followed the Gita Press edition of the Mahabharata for references. We have occasionally cross-referenced other editions, such as the critical edition published by the Bhandarkar Oriental Research Institute (popularly known as the BORI edition) and the southern recension edited by Prof. Krishnacharya (popularly known as the Kumbakonam edition). We have been selective in compiling only those instructions by Krishna which broadly fall within the realm of niti and are generally applicable beyond the contexts in which they were spoken. In this unique attempt to distil a Nitishastra from an Itihasa, we have sought to follow the style of the ancient acharyas of niti, such Chanakya and Kamandaka. We have also tried to avoid repetitions and maintain a degree of brevity in the niti instructions. We have further excluded the celebrated Bhagavad-Gita and Anugita from this compilation,

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since their subject matter deals primarily with adhyatma or spiritual knowledge. Moreover, much has already been written on these two widely known songs of instruction.

We would like to acknowledge the research assistance provided by Deepak Pandey and the team of Saṃskṛta Hitāya in assembling this compilation. We also thank Dr. Satyan Sharma and Dr. Nori Sivasenani for providing references to several Dharmashastras. Praveen Tiwari from BluOne Ink deserves special mention for his constant help and support in publishing this work. We are indebted to Shivani Attri for painting the book cover, which depicts Krishna blowing his Panchajanya conch-shell, announcing the decisive victory of dharma (a scene described in chapter 8). Our heartfelt thanks go out to Thanglenhao Haokip, Sushmita Ghosh, and Megha Dey, respectively, for editing, copy-editing, and proofreading the draft of this book and greatly improving it. Finally, we are grateful to Syed Dilshad Ali for designing the cover of the book.

We hope this work will help the readers learn from Krishna's timeless worldly wisdom, which made Sanjaya remark at the end of the Bhagavad-Gita that “wherever there are Krishna and Arjuna, there is ... certain and constant niti”.¹²

Krishna, the Yogeshvara or lord of Yoga, is also Krishna, the Nitishvara or master-strategist. This is the aspect of Krishna which this book intends to celebrate.

Kushagra Aniket, New York

Nityananda Misra, Mumbai

Gita Jayanti

22 December 2023

Note to the Reader

NLESS otherwise indicated, the book, chapter, and verse numbers for the Mahabharata citations in this book refer to the six-volume Gita Press edition of the Mahabharata with a Hindi translation by Ramanarayanadatta Shastri Pandeya “Rama”. For example, the citation 5.95.48 refers to the verse 48 in chapter 95 of book 5 (Udyoga-parvan) in the Gita Press edition.

The citations from the southern recension of the Mahabharata are preceded with the letter “S” for additional clarity. These are also from the Gita Press edition, which does not number the chapters and verses taken from the southern recension. We have assigned sequential numbers to the chapters and verses. For example, the citation S 14.113.19 refers to verse 19 in chapter 113 of book 14 (Ashvamedhika-parvan). While the Gita Press edition has not numbered the chapter or the verse in the body matter, it has assigned numbers 1 to 21 for the twenty-one southern recension chapters following chapter number 92 in the index for this Parvan. Thus, our chapter 113 is numbered 21 in the index of the Gita Press edition, which has two chapters numbered 21 in the index for the Parvan. As this is chapter number 21 after chapter number 92, we use the number 113 for unambiguous reference.

For the original niti verses, we use two sets of numbering. Before each verse, we provide our own numbering, aligned in the centre and typeset in boldface, to indicate the chapter and verse number in this book. After each verse we provide the Gita Press edition reference in parentheses, aligned to the right.

The context of the niti verses is presented before the verses. This is to help the understanding of the verses.

A summary of major learnings from the niti verses in each chapter is presented at the end of the chapter.

Due to their liberal use, words of Sanskrit and Indic origin have not been italicised in the book.

Keeping in mind the ease of both kinds of readers—those who can read Devanagari and those who cannot—we have provided the original Sanskrit verses in both Devanagari and Roman script, the latter using the International Alphabet of Sanskrit Transliteration (IAST) scheme. A transliteration key is not provided as the IAST scheme can be easily learned from the Wikipedia page on IAST.

For better readability, we have used the Hunterian transliteration system, which does not use diacritics, to transliterate Sanskrit words and names throughout the book (except for original verses). IAST is sometimes used for Sanskrit words, quotes, and names in the endnotes.

1

Restraining the Enemy



AFTER the Khandava forest had been burnt, Maya, the asura who was saved from the fire, approached Arjuna and Krishna and asked what he could do for them in return for their kindness. Krishna instructed Maya to construct an inimitable sabha (assembly house and palace) for Yudhishtira. Maya employed 8,000 rakshasa workers and completed the construction of the most beautiful royal sabha on earth for Yudhishtira in fourteen months. Yudhishtira then moved to this new palace.

Many sages, warriors, and kings would often be present in the court of Yudhishtira. One day, Narada arrived at the court and instructed Yudhishtira in rajadharma, the duties of a king. Narada then described to Yudhishtira the sabhas of various lokapalas, including Indra. Upon hearing about King Harishchandra's presence in Indra's sabha, Yudhishtira asked Narada what merit had Harishchandra to become the foremost member of the sabha of Indra. Narada said that King Harishchandra had undertaken the great Rajasuya yajna (royal sacrifice), a performance that made him achieve bliss in Indra's sabha. Narada then informed Yudhishtira of a message from his father Pandu, who also resided in Indra's sabha. Pandu wanted Yudhishtira to perform the Rajasuya yajna.

With a desire to perform the yajna, Yudhishtira consulted his brothers, ministers, sages, and Krishna. Krishna assented to this proposal but added that the yajna would not be completely successful if the many kings imprisoned by the evil Jarasandha were not freed and Jarasandha himself was not defeated. When Yudhishtira expressed his reservations about such an ambitious endeavour, Krishna instructed him and the other Pandavas as follows:

1.1

अर्थानारभते बालो नानुबन्धमवेक्षते ।

तस्मादरिं न मृष्यन्ति बालमर्थपरायणम् ॥

arthānārabhate bālo nānubandhamavekṣate

tasmādarim na mṛṣyanti bālamarthaparāyaṇam

(2.15.14)

“A childish man undertakes tasks without thinking about the consequences. Therefore, the wise do not forgive such an immature enemy engaged in self-interest.”

Krishna then recalled the names of five emperors in itihasa (traditional accounts) and how they attained sovereignty:

1.2

जित्वा जय्यान् यौवनाश्विः पालनाच्च भगीरथः ।

कार्तवीर्यस्तपोवीर्याद्वलात्तु भरतो विभुः ।

ऋद्ध्या मरुत्तस्तान् पञ्च सम्राजस्त्वनुशुश्रुम ।

jitvā jayyān yauvanāśviḥ pālanācca bhagīrathah

kārtavīryastapovīryādbalāttu bharato vibhuḥ

rddhyā maruttastān pañca samrājastvanuśuśruma

(2.15.15–16)

“Yauvanashvi (Mandhata) became an emperor by defeating enemies worth conquering; Bhagiratha by protecting his subjects; Kartavirya by the power of askesis; the mighty Bharata by his strength; and Marutta by his prosperity. We still hear these five names.”¹

1.3

साम्राज्यमिच्छतस्ते तु सर्वाकारं युधिष्ठिर ।

निग्राह्यलक्षणं प्राप्तिर्धर्मार्थनयलक्षणैः ॥

sāmrajyamicchataste tu sarvākāraṃ yudhiṣṭhira
nigrāhyalakṣaṇaṃ prāptirdharmārthanayalakṣaṇaiḥ

(2.15.16–17)

“O Yudhishtira! You desire sovereignty in all these ways: with a victory flag, protection of people, righteousness, prosperity, and policy.”²

Since Yudhishtira had already excelled in all the qualities except the first, Krishna called upon him to attack Jarasandha. Krishna concluded by invoking the Kshatriya code of war:

1.4

क्षत्रियः शस्त्रमरणो यदा भवति सत्कृतः ।

ततः स्म मागधं संख्ये प्रतिबाधेम यद्वयम् ॥

kṣatriyaḥ śastramarāṇo yadā bhavati satkṛtaḥ
tataḥ sma māgadhaṃ saṁkhye pratibādhema yadvayam

(2.15.23)

“When a Kshatriya is killed with weapons in a battle, then he is honoured. Therefore, let us restrain the king of Magadha in combat.”

Bhima proposed that he, with the help of Krishna and Arjuna, would accomplish the task of slaying Jarasandha. Yudhishtira was reluctant and unsure of victory. He said he was no longer interested in performing the Rajasuya Yajna, as all this seemed very difficult. Arjuna tried to encourage him and said that not undertaking the Rajasuya Yajna would be a sign of weakness. Krishna further exhorted Yudhishtira to combat Jarasandha as follows:

1.5

न स्म मृत्युं वयं विद्म रात्रौ वा यदि वा दिवा ।

न चापि कञ्चिदमरमयुद्धेनानुशुश्रुम ॥

na sma mṛtyuṃ vayam vidma rātrau vā yadi vā divā

na cāpi kañcidamaramayuddhenānuśuśruma

(2.17.2)

“We do not know whether we will meet our death in the day or at night. Nor have we heard of anyone who became immortal by not fighting.”

1.6

एतावदेव पुरुषैः कार्यं हृदयतोषणम् ।

नयेन विधिदृष्टेन यदुपक्रमते परान् ॥

etāvadeva puruṣaiḥ kāryaṃ hṛdayatoṣaṇam

nayena vidhidṛṣṭena yadupakramate parān

(2.17.3)

“Therefore, brave men should do just this for the satisfaction of their heart—attack their enemies as per the strategy seen in scriptures (Nitishastra).”

1.7

सुनयस्यानपायस्य संयोगे परमः क्रमः ।

सङ्गत्या जायतेऽसाम्यं साम्यं च न भवेद्वयोः ॥

sunayasyānapāyasya saṁyoge paramaḥ kramaḥ
saṅgatyā jāyate'sāmyaṁ sāmīyaṁ ca na bhaveddvayoḥ

(2.17.4)

“An excellent task succeeds when the strategy is good and there are no obstacles. A superiority results from a confrontation, for the two opponents are not the same.”³

1.8

अनयस्यानुपायस्य संयुगे परमः क्षयः ।

संशयो जायते साम्याज्जयश्च न भवेद्वयोः ॥

anayasyānupāyasya saṁyuge paramaḥ kṣayaḥ
saṁśayo jāyate sāmīyājīyāśca na bhaveddvayoḥ

(2.17.5)

“In a battle, one without any strategy and means meets with a crushing defeat. Similarity of opponents gives rise to doubt and [if both are doubtful,] none of them is victorious.”⁴

1.9

ते वयं नयमास्थाय शत्रुदेहसमीपगाः ।

कथमन्तं न गच्छेम वृक्षस्येव नदीरयाः ।

पररन्ध्रे पराक्रान्ताः स्वरन्ध्रावरणे स्थिताः ॥

te vayaṁ nayamāsthāya śatrudehasamīpagāḥ
kathamantaṁ na gacchema vṛkṣasyeva nadīrayāḥ
pararandhre parākṛāntāḥ svarandhrāvaraṇe sthitāḥ

(2.17.6)

“Resorting to the right strategy, exploiting the enemy’s weaknesses and hiding ours, when we approach the enemy himself, why would we not destroy him like the currents of a river uproot a tree?”⁵

1.10

व्यूढानीकैरतिबलैर्न युद्धेदरिभिः सह ।
इति बुद्धिमतां नीतिस्तन्ममापीह रोचते ॥

vyūḍhānikairatibalairna yuddhyedaribhiḥ saha
iti buddhimatām nītistanmamāpīha rocate

(2.17.7)

“One should not fight [directly] with very powerful enemies who command arrayed troops. This strategy of the wise is agreeable to me also in this situation.”

1.11

अनवद्या ह्यसम्बुद्धाः प्रविष्टाः शत्रुसद्म तत् ।
शत्रुदेहमुपाक्रम्य तं कामं प्राप्नुयामहे ॥

anavadyā hyasambuddhāḥ praviṣṭāḥ śatrusadma tat
śatrudehamupākramya taṁ kāmam prāpnuyāmahe

(2.17.8)

“Not making any mistakes and not being identified, we will enter the enemy’s abode, attack the enemy himself and fulfil this wish.”

Krishna then narrated the account of Jarasandha’s birth and life. He convinced Yudhishtira that Bhima was strong enough to defeat Jarasandha. Krishna then requested that Yudhishtira

send Arjuna and Bhima with him to Magadha. Yudhishtira agreed. The three travelled to Magadha.

Unarmed and disguised as Brahmanas, they entered the capital of Magadha and reached the palace of Jarasandha. Jarasandha welcomed them and made arrangements for their stay in the yajna-shala (worship hall). At midnight, Jarasandha went to see them and asked them who they really were, as the three were dressed as Brahmanas, but their arms had marks of bowstrings that Kshatriyas have. Jarasandha also asked why they had entered the city secretly and in disguise. Krishna responded to Jarasandha as follows:

1.12

क्षत्रियो बाहुवीर्यस्तु न तथा वाक्यवीर्यवान् ।

अप्रगल्भं वचस्तस्य तस्माद्बार्हद्रथेरितम् ॥

kṣatriyo bāhuvīryastu na tathā vākyaavīryavān
apragalbhaṃ vacastasya tasmādbārhadratheritam

(2.21.51)

“The strength of a Kshatriya lies in his arms, not so much in his words. Therefore, O son of Brihadratha, the speech of a Kshatriya is known to be modest.”

1.13

अद्वारेण रिपोर्गेहं द्वारेण सुहृदो गृहान् ।

प्रविशन्ति नरा धीरा द्वाराण्येतानि धर्मतः ॥

advāreṇa riporgehaṃ dvāreṇa suhr̥do gṛhān
praviśanti narā dhīrā dvārāṇyetāni dharmataḥ

(2.21.53)

“Wise men enter an enemy’s house without using the door and the abodes of their friends through the door. These are the doors as per dharma.”⁶

1.14

कार्यवन्तो गृहानेत्य शत्रुतो नार्हणां वयम्।

प्रतिगृह्णीम तद्विद्धि एतन्नः शाश्वतं व्रतम्॥

**kāryavanto grhānetya śatruto nārhaṇām vayam
pratigṛhṇīma tadviddhi etannaḥ śāśvataṁ vratam**

(2.21.54)

“Having entered a dwelling with a specific objective, we do not accept honour from an enemy. Know this to be our eternal vow.”

When Krishna said that they would not accept any honour from an enemy, Jarasandha asked them why they considered him their enemy and added that he could not recall if he had wronged them in any way. Krishna responded by saying that Jarasandha was guilty of imprisoning many kings and intending to sacrifice them to worship Rudra. Krishna first cautioned and then challenged Jarasandha as follows:

1.15

यस्यां यस्यामवस्थायां यद्यत्कर्म करोति यः।

तस्यां तस्यामवस्थायां तत्फलं समवाप्नुयात्॥

**yasyāṁ yasyāmavasthāyāṁ yadyatkarma karoti yaḥ
tasyāṁ tasyāmavasthāyāṁ tatphalaṁ samavāpnuyāt**

(2.22.13)

“Whatever action one performs in whatever situation, they get its fruit in that very situation.”⁷

1.16

स्वर्गं ह्येव समास्थाय रणयज्ञेषु दीक्षिताः ।

जयन्ति क्षत्रिया लोकांस्तद्विद्धि मनुजर्षभ ॥

svargaṃ hyeva samāsthāya raṇayajñeṣu dikṣitāḥ

jayanti kṣatriyā lokāṃstadviddhi manujaṛṣabha

(2.22.17)

“Desirous of only svarga and initiated in the yajna of battle, Kshatriyas conquer all people. Understand this, O best among men!”⁸

1.17

स्वर्गयोनिर्महद्ब्रह्म स्वर्गयोनिर्महद्यशः ।

स्वर्गयोनिस्तपो युद्धे मृत्युः सोऽव्यभिचारवान् ॥

svargayonirmahadbrahma svargayonirmahadyaśaḥ

svargayonistapo yuddhe mṛtyuḥ so’vyabhicāravān

(2.22.18)

“The great Veda, eminent fame and askesis are means of attaining svarga. Death in a battle is a certain means.”⁹

Krishna then warned Jarasandha against excessive pride. He said to Jarasandha:

1.18

मावमंस्थाः परान् राजन्नस्ति वीर्यं नरे नरे ।

समं तेजस्त्वया चैव विशिष्टं वा नरेश्वर ॥

**māvamamsthāḥ parān rājannasti vīryam nare nare
samaṁ tejastvayā caiva viśiṣṭam vā nareśvara**
(2.22.21)

“O king! Do not disregard others. There is strength in each and every man. Moreover, O lord of men, the strength of some is equal to yours or even more than it.”

1.19

**दम्भोद्धवः कार्तवीर्य उत्तरश्च बृहद्रथः ।
श्रेयसो ह्यवमन्येह विनेशुः सबला नृपाः ॥**

**dambhodbhavaḥ kārtavīrya uttaraśca bṛhadrathaḥ
śreyaso hyavamanyeha vineśuḥ sabalā nṛpāḥ**
(2.22.24)

“Dambhodbhava, Kartavirya Arjuna, Uttara and Brihadratha—these kings perished on this earth with their armies after disregarding those who were superior to them.”¹⁰

Krishna then revealed the true identity of Bhima, Arjuna, and himself to Jarasandha. He challenged Jarasandha to a duel. He taunted Jarasandha by saying that he should either release all the imprisoned kings or go to the abode of Yama after being killed in a fight. Krishna then asked him to choose one of Bhima, Arjuna, or Krishna as an opponent. Jarasandha chose Bhima.

The wrestling battle (mallayuddha) between Bhima and Jarasandha began. It went on for fourteen days, without a break. On the fourteenth night, Jarasandha started showing signs of exhaustion. As soon as Krishna noticed Jarasandha was

tired, he advised Bhima thus:

1.20

क्लान्तः शत्रुर्न कौन्तेय लभ्यः पीडयितुं रणे ।

पीड्यमानो हि कात्स्न्येन जह्याज्जीवितमात्मनः ॥

klāntaḥ śaturna kaunteya labhyaḥ pīdayituṃ raṇe
pīḍyamāno hi kārtsnyena jahyāj्jīvitamātmanah

(2.23.32)

“O son of Kunti! It is not right to torment an enemy who is already fatigued. If tormented for long, the enemy may lose his life completely.”

Although Krishna appears to advise Bhima to stop tormenting Jarasandha, Nilakantha Chaturdhara, in his commentary, says that he spoke such words out of etiquette and actually signalled Bhima to do exactly the opposite, i.e., to end Jarasandha’s suffering by killing him.¹¹

Bhima killed Jarasandha in the duel. All the kings imprisoned by Jarasandha were freed. The released kings honoured Krishna. Krishna gave an assurance of safety to Jarasandha’s son Sahadeva and then returned to Indraprastha with Bhima and Arjuna. After narrating the account of Bhima’s victory and the release of all the imprisoned kings to Yudhishtira, Krishna met with everybody in Indraprastha and then left for Dvaraka.

SUMMARY

He who is rash is childish. Wise is he who attacks a reckless enemy. Subjugating enemies, protecting the subjects, practising askesis or dharma, acquiring power and attaining prosperity are the means of creating an empire. Warriors and soldiers should not fear death. Not fighting the enemies and the evil does not achieve anything. Brave men should attack their enemies strategically.

A good strategy and the absence of obstacles are the keys to military success. It is only after a confrontation that one can emerge superior. One should never go into battle without a strategy and without the means, as that leads to a crushing defeat. As long as one is doubtful, one cannot gain an edge. Employing the right strategy, attacking the opponent's vulnerabilities, and hiding one's own vulnerabilities ensures victory. One should not fight directly with an opponent who is very strong and has a large army. In indirect warfare, not making mistakes and not leaving any tracks are crucial.

True warriors are humble in their words and instead show their valour on the battlefield. Wise men meet their friends publicly but approach their enemies secretly. One should be careful of accepting honours from an enemy. Whatever action one performs, they are sure to get its fruit. Every man can fight. Therefore, one should not disregard anybody's strength as there is always somebody as powerful as or more powerful than them. Disregarding those who are superior leads to one's destruction.

Restraining the Enemy

A battle must not be prolonged if the opponent has become weak; instead, it should be quickly ended.

Notes

Preface

1. The Mahabharata 6.23.28, 6.43.60 and 9.62.31.
2. The Mahabharata 6.66.35 and 13.167.41.
3. यतः सत्यं यतो धर्मो यतो ह्रीराजवं यतः, ततो भवति गोविन्दो यतः कृष्णस्ततो जयः (the Mahabharata 5.68.9).
4. यत्र धर्मो द्युतिः कान्तिर्यत्र ह्रीः श्रीस्तथा मतिः, यतो धर्मस्ततो कृष्णो यतः कृष्णस्ततो जयः (the Mahabharata 6.23.28).
5. यतो धर्मस्ततो कृष्णो यतः कृष्णस्ततो जयः, युध्यस्व गच्छ कौन्तेय [पृच्छ मां किं ब्रवीमि ते] (the Mahabharata 6.43.60).
6. राजन् सर्वमयो ह्येष तमोरागविवर्जितः, यतः कृष्णस्ततो धर्मो यतो धर्मस्ततो जयः (the Mahabharata 6.66.35).
7. उपप्लव्ये महर्षिर्मे कृष्णद्वैपायनोऽब्रवीत्, यतो धर्मस्ततः कृष्णो यतः कृष्णस्ततो जयः (the Mahabharata 9.62.31).
8. उक्तवानस्मि दुर्बुद्धिं मन्दं दुर्योधनं तदा, यतः कृष्णस्ततो धर्मो यतो धर्मस्ततो जयः (the Mahabharata 13.167.40-41).
9. कृष्णे नयो मयि बलं जयः पार्थे धनञ्जये, मागधं साधयिष्याम इष्टिं त्रय इवाग्नयः (the Mahabharata 2.15.13).
10. The Mahabharata 1.139.
11. विवर्धध्वं ज्वलना इवैधमानाः (the Mahabharata 1.190.25)
12. The Bhagavad-Gita (18.78): यत्र योगेश्वरः कृष्णो यत्र पार्थो धनुर्धरः, तत्र श्रीर्विजयो भूतिर्ध्रुवा नीतिर्मतिर्मम. “Where there is Krishna, the lord of Yoga, and Arjuna, the bowman, there reside fortune, victory, prosperity, and certain and constant niti. Such is my conviction.”

Chapter 1: Restraining the Enemy

1. Nilakantha explains that the enemies worth conquering are both external (other kings) and internal (lust, anger, pride, greed, attachment, and jealousy). A variant reading is हित्वा करान् यौवनाश्विः; it means Mandhata became an emperor by abolishing taxes. This is the reading translated by K.M. Ganguli and M.N. Dutt.
2. The last hemistich is abstruse. Our translation is influenced by the commentary of Nilakantha, who links the hemistich to the five qualities of the five aforementioned emperors: the flag of victory to Yauvanashvi, protection of people to Bhagiratha, dharma (which he explains as yoga) to Kartavirya, prosperity to Marutta, and naya/niti (which he explains as the power of policy) to Bharata. Interestingly, Nilakantha gives a variant reading with an additional hemistich, मन्त्रान् वश्यानुमृशन्नेवमेव सतां युगे, before a variant reading of the last hemistich, निग्राह्यलक्षणं प्राप्तो धर्मार्थनयलक्षणैः. This is connected with the following verse to explain it in the context of Jarasandha. K.M. Ganguli, M.N. Dutt, and R.S. Pandeya 'Rama' more or less follow Nilakantha and do not translate the variant reading.
3. Nilakantha explains the essence of the second half as follows: without a confrontation, it is not possible to know for certain whether one is capable of winning and inaction due to apprehensions about one's capability results in defeat.
4. Krishna refers to the word *upāya*, which means "an instrument to achieve one's goals". The four *upāyas* or political expedients, viz., *sāman* (negotiation), *dāna* (donation or bribery), *daṇḍa* (punishment), and *bheda* (sowing dissensions), are widely known. Kamandaka adds three others: *māyā* (deceit), *upekṣā* (neglect), and *indrajāla* (trickery). Says the Nitisara of Kamandaka (18.3):

साम दानञ्च भेदश्च दण्डश्चेति चतुष्टयम्, मायोपेक्षेन्द्रजालञ्च सप्तोपायाः प्रकीर्त्तिताः.

5. Krishna implies that to destroy an enemy, one needs to have the right strategy, exploit all the vulnerabilities of the opponent, and not reveal any vulnerability of one's own.
6. Literally, अद्वारेण means "through a non-door". The sense is to enter not using the main or public door or gate but through a secret entrance or secretly. Another sense is to enter without being noticed. Some editions of the Mahabharata, including the Bhandarkar Oriental Research Institute (BORI) edition, have सुहृदो गृहम् as a variant reading with गृहम् in singular. This translates as "[to] the house of a friend". According to the Manusmriti (4.73), one should always enter a village or house through its designated gate: अद्वारेण च नातीयाद्ग्रामं वा वेश्म वाऽवृत्तम्, रात्रौ च वृक्षमूलानि दूरतः परिवर्जयेत्. However, Krishna makes an exception when entering the abode of one's enemy. In the Ramayana (5.4.2), Hanuman followed the same strategy when he entered Lanka through a "non-entrance" or an unguarded gate: अद्वारेण च महाबाहुः प्राकारमभिपुप्लुवे, प्रविश्य नगरीं लङ्कां कपिराजहितंकरः.
7. Variations of this verse appear throughout the Mahabharata, e.g., in Vidura's advice to Dhritarashtra (11.2.23) and Bhishma's instruction to Yudhishtira after the war (13.7.4).
8. The word लोकान् in the verse can be translated as either "[to] people" or "[to] realms". This message of a battle being the gateway to svarga was repeated by Krishna in his sermon to Arjuna in the Bhagavad-Gita (2.32).
9. Krishna implies that the attainment of svarga by the three other acts may be uncertain, but death in battle will certainly help attain it.
10. Out of the four kings mentioned here, the stories of Dambhodbhava and Kartavirya Arjuna are known to us.

Assuming that the Uttara mentioned by Krishna is not the same as the prince of the Matsya kingdom, the story of this king is not known to us. Similarly, while several kings named Brihadratha are mentioned in the Puranas, we do not come across any particular character known for his contemptuous behaviour.

The story of Dambhodbhava is often cited in Nitishastra as an example of downfall due to his hubris. Dambhodbhava was a valiant king who conquered the entire world. Every morning, he asked if anyone was equal or superior to him in valour. Directed by the Brahmanas to the Gandhamadana mountain, Dambhodbhava sought a duel with Rishi Nara and Rishi Narayana, who were engrossed in their penance. The sages refused and asked him to seek another opponent but Dambhodbhava remained adamant. Finally, Rishi Nara asked Dambhodbhava to attack with all his might. Dambhodbhava enveloped the sage in arrows from all directions, but Rishi Nara repulsed them all. Then Rishi Nara grabbed a blade of grass and released it as his weapon, destroying Dambhodbhava's entire army and humbling the arrogant king. Dambhodbhava begged the sages for forgiveness. The sages pardoned the king and directed him to return to his kingdom, with the promise to treat everyone equally. The Nitisara of Kamandaka (1.59) states that Dambhodbhava was killed due to excessive pride: पौलस्त्यो राक्षसो मानान्मदाद्भोद्धवो नृपः, प्रयाता निधनं ह्येते शत्रुषड्वर्गमाश्रिताः.

About Kartavirya Arjuna, it is said that no other king has been or would be able to match him in sacrifices, charity, austerity, yoga, learning, strength, and mercy. The Bhagavata-Purana (9.23.25) regards Kartavirya Arjuna to be an unparalleled ruler: न नूनं कार्तवीर्यस्य गतिं यास्यन्ति पार्थिवाः, यज्ञदानतपोयोगैः श्रुतवीर्यदयादिभिः. Kartavirya was a descendant of the Haihaya dynasty. He was a mighty king who ruled over a large kingdom from his

capital, Mahishmati. He was also known as Sahasrarjuna and Sahasrabahu, as he had a thousand arms due to a boon. Renowned for his valour in battle, he defeated several kings, including Ravana, the rakshasa ruler of Lanka. Soon, Kartavirya became intoxicated with power and began oppressing his subjects. He entered into a dispute with Rishi Jamadagni by appropriating his divine cow, Kamadhenu. When the conflict escalated, Kartavirya beheaded the unarmed sage, incurring the wrath of Parashurama, the young son of Jamadagni. Ultimately, Parashurama took revenge for the death of his father by killing Kartavirya, along with his entire clan of Kshatriyas, in battle.

11. Nilakantha Chaturdhara comments on this verse: “As if by the excuse of demonstrating good behaviour, (Krishna is) signalling the time of the enemy’s death” (शिष्टाचारप्रदर्शनव्याजेन शत्रुवधकालं सूचयन्निव).

Chapter 2: Post-Mortem of a Crisis

1. The word *nikṛti*, whose instrumental form *nikṛtyā* is used in this verse, refers to dishonesty, fraud, or wickedness. The word *vadhya* can mean both “fit to be killed” and “fit to be beaten or corporally punished”, for *vadha* means both “killing” and “beating”. For example, in contexts like *rāvaṇasya vadham ghoram rāghavasya parākramam* (“the violent killing of Rāvaṇa and the valour of Rāma”, Rāmāyaṇa CE 6.100.2), the word *vadha* means “killing”. In contrast, in contexts like *śiṣyaśiṣṭir-avadhena* (“a disciple should be punished without beating”, Gautama-Dharmasūtra 1.2.48), the word *vadha* means “beating”, as clarified by the Mitākṣarā commentary of Haradatta Miśra who says on this verse: *vadhas-tāḍanam* (“the word *vadha* means beating”). Many Sanskrit dictionaries, including Apte, give both

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